

Water

Many women find being in warm water during labor very soothing and a helpful way to cope with labor pain. In addition to taking some pressure off your pelvis, water also relaxes your muscles, and eases tension and stress. The warmth of the water soothes your muscles and promotes relaxation. Being in water aids buoyancy, which can help relieve the pressure on your pelvis. Over the last decade or so, this natural method has become more available for women, and many hospitals and birth centers provide bathtubs. Due to increased risks of infection, however, it is recommended that you do not deliver in the water.



Laboring in warm water can be deeply soothing. In addition to helping take the pressure off your pelvis, water also relaxes muscles, in turn easing tension and stress.

Hypnosis

Self-hypnosis, using visualization and breathing techniques to induce a state of deep relaxation and banish fear, is an increasingly popular means of dealing with labor, and is referred to as “HypnoBirthing.” This is based on the “fear-tension-pain” syndrome of childbirth first described by the British obstetrician Grantly Dick-Read, who believed that fear prevents the release of the “feel-good hormones,” endorphins and encephalins. He maintained that when fear is eliminated, most women can give birth naturally. With HypnoBirthing, you are fully aware of what is happening around you, but may feel as though you’re daydreaming or drifting off to sleep. You and your birth partner can attend HypnoBirthing classes anytime during pregnancy to learn the techniques before labor. To find a class in your area, visit hypnobirthing.com/findapract.htm.

RELAXATION TECHNIQUES
